Babuji had passed away when we were in France, so we did not get to see him again. We looked forward to those weekend stays for we would be spoilt silly. I would help my grandfather in the daily prayers; taking down the idols from the *dev-ghar,* placing them in a copper *thali*, bathing the various gods, before reverentially putting them back and adorning them with fresh flowers that Dada had plucked from the garden early in the morning, and a 'tika' with freshly ground sandalwood paste. We would then chant the prayer together, '. . . *Manojavam Marutatulyavegam* . . .', referring to Lord Hanuman, chief of the *vanara sena*, which for some reason, was the part I liked most. During the day, we used to play with our friends, many of them day scholars in the same school. There was a huge mango tree in the adjacent vacant plot, which was our favourite hangout. Playing *pithu* (seven stones) was another favourite pastime. I used to be quite unhappy when the weekend drew to a close, especially since the first period on Monday used to be Hindi. Playing with our schoolmates over the weekends gave us an idea—why can't we be day scholars too? The next year, we did just that and were much happier, though it did mean commuting daily in the Pune Municipal Transport bus from Nal stop to Deccan Gymkhana, and then from Deccan Gymkhana to Camp, the to-and-fro fare being a grand sum of 30 paise. That interlude did not last long though, as my father got posted to Delhi.

By then, my sister had joined Fergusson College to study—what else—French. By the time we returned from France, my sister was already in the last year of school, so it was natural that she would go in for a language course in college and make it her career. She taught French in many schools and colleges, including the prestigious National Defence Academy (though after my time), before finally joining the French Department

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